



Q Are there any foods or drinks that I should limit or cut out now that I'm pregnant?

Knowing what foods and drinks to avoid helps your health and the safe development of your baby. Some foods contain, or may contain, bacteria or substances that may make you sick or be harmful to your baby. While this may seem very alarming, it's worth remembering that the risks are very low.



Health and hygiene

You are more vulnerable to infections while pregnant, so being aware of what you eat and drink and following good food hygiene principles are necessary precautions.

Food hygiene is straightforward if you are vigilant. Always check the sell-by dates on food product labels and reject any food that smells off or looks suspect. Wash your hands before and after handling food, and rinse fruit, salads, and vegetables to remove traces of soil and pesticides. Be extra careful with raw poultry and meat: use separate chopping boards and knives, and wash them afterward with detergent in very hot water. Defrost

frozen foods carefully according to the instructions on the packaging, and if you reheat cooked food in the microwave, make sure that the whole dish is piping hot.

Avoid foods (listed below) that may carry harmful bacteria, parasites, or cause food poisoning; some herbal teas and sugar substitutes; smoking; recreational drugs; alcohol; and limit caffeine. If you drank alcohol or smoked before you discovered you were pregnant, don't be anxious but stop now. The fetus will start being supported by the placenta from 12 weeks, although it can't protect an unborn baby against all infections and bacteria.

FOODS TO LIMIT OR AVOID

Although there is usually only a small risk that foods such as these may prove harmful to your baby, they are best avoided or limited while you are pregnant.



Banned foods Cured meats and unpasteurized cheeses should be avoided.

FOOD	YOU SHOULD AVOID	RELATED PROBLEMS	YOU CAN EAT
Cheese	» Any unpasteurized cheese. » Soft mold-ripened cheeses (with a "white rind"), such as Camembert and Brie. » Uncooked soft blue cheeses, such as Roquefort and Gorgonzola.	In rare cases, cheese may carry the listeria bacteria. Listeriosis (listeria infection) may cause only mild, flu-like symptoms in you, but it can be harmful to your baby and in severe cases can lead to brain damage.	» Hard cheeses and hard blue cheeses (such as Parmesan, Gouda, Cheddar, and Stilton). » Soft cheeses made with pasteurized milk—for example cottage cheese, cream cheese, mozzarella, feta, and ricotta.
Meat	» Raw or undercooked red meat. » Cold cuts and luncheon meats. » Liver or other organ meats, and liver pâté—they contain high levels of vitamin A.	Undercooked meat may be infected with the toxoplasmosis parasite and cold cuts may contain listeria. Both may harm your baby. Too much vitamin A can cause birth defects and harm your baby's liver.	» Meat that has been cooked to a safe temperature is fine to eat. Cold cuts are fine, too, if they are served hot, or have been cooked.
Seafood	» Uncooked shellfish. » Avoid shark, marlin, and swordfish, which contain high levels of mercury.	Food poisoning from seafood is unpleasant for you, but it doesn't pose any health risks to your developing baby. High levels of mercury, found in certain fish, can be harmful to your baby's nervous system.	» Oily fish, but only once or twice a week, since it may contain toxins such as PCBs and dioxins (as well as lots of good nutrients). » Cooked shellfish.
Eggs	» Raw eggs and raw egg products such as mayonnaise and mousse. » Undercooked eggs—eat only if the yolk and white are solid.	There is a tiny risk that raw eggs may contain the salmonella bacteria. A salmonella infection is not thought to be harmful to an unborn baby, but can cause vomiting and diarrhea for you.	» Choose eggs stamped to show that they have been laid in conditions following the strictest hygiene.